

# Luke Blaney BSc (Hons)

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## Employment

### Cyber Security Director

Financial Times: February 2023 - March 2025

Set strategic direction for cyber security at the FT.

- Defined the vision and set the strategy for IT Risk and Cyber Security.
- Senior stakeholder management - acting as a bridge between business colleagues and engineers.
- Introduced and oversaw a new process for renewing and refreshing technical policies across the organisation, increasing discoverability of policies and improving adherence.
- Led security incident management and contributed to a new company-wide crisis management team.
- Spent 3 months on secondment to the FT's parent company, Nikkei, in Tokyo. Assisted their product security function and strengthened ties between the two companies.
- Throughout this period, also held the unbackfilled Principal Engineer responsibilities for Cyber Security — providing the technical direction that role usually requires, while delegating day-to-day team management to senior engineers on the team.

### Interim VP of Cyber Security

Financial Times: April 2022 - January 2023

Led the company's cyber security function through a period of organisational change.

- Built a new centralised cyber security function, bringing together people, process and budgets from across the organisation. This reduced barriers in communication and led to better-aligned security outcomes.
- Line managed a mixed-discipline team of a dozen people, including Engineers, Risk Analysts and IT governance roles.
- Steered the direction of Security work across the technology department, and the organisation as a whole.
- Worked with a third party consultancy to build a strategic roadmap and help prioritise security initiatives.
- Involved in recruitment of a permanent VP of Cyber Security.
- Continued the Principal Engineer technical-direction responsibilities for Cyber Security throughout this period, as the PE position had not been backfilled when I moved up.

### Principal Engineer - Observability, Edge Delivery & Cyber Security

Financial Times: September 2021 - March 2022

Working on the strategic direction in three key areas across the FT's technology department.

- Responsible for line management of 2 in-house engineering teams, plus the relationship with an off-shore 3rd party engineering team.
- Worked on vendor management of key suppliers within relevant domains and set the direction of the FT's relationships with them.
- Steered changes to the department's approach to tracking security risk with an aim to make it more outcome-focused.
- Analysis of how observability and security tooling is being used across the company and putting in place strategic plans for these, including end-of-life roadmaps for tools which give minimal value.
- Recruited engineers for vacancies within our teams, including both internal & external candidates. Aimed to keep diversity and equity at forefront of hiring decisions, including actively modifying our recruitment process following feedback from neurodiverse candidates.

### Principal Engineer - Cyber Security

Financial Times: September 2020 - September 2021

Leading the engineering function of the FT's cyber security team.

- Acted as tech lead and line manager for engineers in the cyber security team
- Rolled out a new company-wide security incident management process and took the lead on managing security incidents.
- Took responsibility for shaping the team's roadmap and seeing projects through to completion.
- Contributed to group-wide strategy, ensuring security was well represented.
- Led the strategy and implementation of democratisation of security data — enabling engineering teams to make better decisions around their own risks.
- Advised on security related concerns across all the FT's engineering teams.
- Took over responsibility for the company-wide migration of Single Sign-On platform, which had been behind schedule and lacking direction. Delivered it on time and on budget.

## Principal Engineer - Reliability Engineering

Financial Times: February 2018 - August 2020

Running a new team, set up to improve reliability of systems and reduce duplication of effort across technology teams at the FT.

- Formed a brand new team whose members had backgrounds in a variety of different domains.
- Jointly led the team, taking on line management responsibilities for half its members.
- Supported engineers from other teams joining us on three-month secondments.
- Actively involved in the full recruitment process for new members of the team.
- Was a department rep for the move of our company headquarters. In collaboration with reps from across the business, I worked representing the 300+ people in our area, ensuring they could make the move seamlessly.
- Oversaw the delivery of several core technical tools, now used extensively across the company, including a monitoring aggregation platform, tech migration tracker and change management system.
- Worked with engineering teams throughout the department to build a clearer understanding of our estate (including bespoke software, enterprise systems and SaaS solutions)
- Successfully led and completed the company-wide migration of several engineering tools from on-premise software to Software-as-a-Service alternatives, including Code Hosting and Issue Tracking platforms. As part of this, I did the vendor management, led technical migration strategy and project managed the end-to-end moves.

## Architect - Content

Financial Times: October 2016 - February 2018

Worked on our Universal Publishing Platform, which delivers Content & Metadata from a range of editorial tools to our websites, apps and third-party B2B clients.

- Responsible for architectural decisions across a whole programme of work — 6 development teams across 2 countries, building a platform of 100+ microservices.
- Worked on an event-driven architecture using Apache Kafka to move content and metadata across editorial systems, web/app delivery, and B2B clients. Made architectural decisions about event flows and data contracts; configuration and operations were owned by engineers on the platform.
- Architected the move to Kubernetes for 5 engineering squads in a business-critical area, simplifying operations and reducing technical risk.
- Pivoted the architect role from a decision bottleneck to a more consultative one, giving engineering squads more autonomy for day-to-day decisions.
- Designed a suite of new APIs to power an in-house metadata management tool for the newsroom.
- Worked closely with stakeholders from Editorial, B2B and Technology departments.
- Successfully repositioned our relationship with an existing supplier so they'd take on operational responsibility for the software they were building.
- Planned and co-ordinated a multi-team, multi-year programme to replace a suite of legacy on-premise business-critical software with a mix of SaaS solutions and cloud-hosted bespoke microservices.
- Devised a framework for tracking progress on the legacy decommissioning, in a way that made sense to both delivery managers and engineers.
- Took on line management responsibilities for 2 integration engineers.

I think my proudest accomplishment here was transforming a team heavily reliant on having an architect to one where engineers felt empowered to make their own architectural decisions.

## Platform Architect - Operational Intelligence

Financial Times: December 2015 - October 2016

Technical lead on a team responsible for observability tools used across the department (covering monitoring, metrics & log aggregation). We also replaced the organisation's CMDB with a new system for tracking the FT's technical estate, which provided automated runbook creation, monitoring management, and bridged the gap between Engineering and Operations teams. My role included:

- System design, development and backlog prioritisation
- Upskilling a team from disparate backgrounds and recruitment of junior developers
- Collaborating with delivery to move the team to a kanban agile workflow
- Working with teams across the FT and third-party suppliers

## Integration Engineer - Strategic Products

Financial Times: January 2015 - November 2015

Led the migration of the FT's mobile apps to cloud-based infrastructure (primarily AWS) to facilitate the switch-off of physical kit in our datacentres. This involved:

- Adapted existing workloads to run on cloud
- Recruitment of a contractor to assist with the project
- Architected & development of a cloud-native zero-downtime deployment pipeline

## Labs Developer - FT Labs

Financial Times: December 2011 - December 2014

In this role, I gained experience with the full stack of web development technologies, from using bleeding-edge browser features in the FT's HTML5 Web App, through to server management and configuration using tools like Puppet, Varnish and Apache.

- Worked on the original incarnation of FastFT, a real-time news service. This included a customer-facing frontend, an API and bespoke CMS for editorial users.
- Led FT Labs' internal tooling workstream, which focused on infrastructure improvements and developer experience (including deployment, live error collection and monitoring aggregation). My role involved engineering, architectural decisions and co-ordinating the work of others in this area.
- Following a cyber attack in 2013, I architected, helped engineer and co-ordinated roll-out of a tool to put multifactor authentication in front of all of the FT's staff-facing tools.

## Web Developer

Assanka: November 2010 - December 2011

Worked on various web projects for a range of clients, doing both backend and frontend work. Backends included Wordpress, an in-house framework and vanilla PHP. Frontend javascript varied from simple jQuery-based interfaces, to large object-orientated systems which utilised many HTML5 features. Assanka was acquired by the Financial Times at the end of 2011 and was later rebranded "FT Labs".

## Talks & Panels

- **Panel: Building security into your engineering workflow | LeadDev 2021** Moderated an online panel about improving cyber security across engineering organisations.
- **Panel: Observability Strategies for Distributed Systems | InfoQ Live 2020**  
Discussed approaches for observability when using microservices at this one-day online conference.
- **Monitoring All the Things: Keeping Track of a Mixed Estate | QCon London 2020; Continuous Lifecycle 2020**  
Spoke about effectively monitoring the tech estate of a company which uses a variety of different technologies and monitoring approaches.
- **Panel: Microservices — Are they still worth it? | QCon London 2020**  
Discussed the ongoing value of microservices architecture in a panel at the same event.
- **Panel: Standardisation and autonomy in our tech choices | Engine Room, London 2019**  
Discussed the value of consistency versus local optimisation in our technical approaches at the FT's internal tech

conference.

- **Panel: Do we only measure things that are easy to measure? | Engine Room, London 2017**  
Chaired a panel discussing the use of metrics in tech and product decisions at the FT's internal tech conference.
- **Creating a multi-factor authentication solution | Varnish Summit & Awards, Los Angeles 2016**  
Spoke about how the FT used varnish to protect our estate with MFA and tackle phishing attacks. Also collected the Varnish Innovation Award at the same event.
- **Panel: Page Load Performance | Edgeconf, London 2014**  
Discussed performance best practices when using cutting edge web technologies.
- **One VCL to rule all our environments | Varnish User Group, Berlin 2013**  
Spoke about the consolidation of our caching and routing logic across environments using puppet.

For a full list of Talks & Panels I've done, see <https://lukeblaney.co.uk/talks/>

## Education

### BSc (Hons) Computer Science and Physics

Edinburgh University: 2006 - 2010

A joint degree, with an emphasis on Computer Science, covering specialist areas such as Distributed Systems, Multi-Agent Semantic Web Systems, Computer Security and Communication & Networking. My Honours project used Semantic Web technologies to provide data for a Semi-Automatic Guesstimation system.

### A-levels and GCSEs

Lagan College, Belfast: 1999 - 2006

- **A-levels:** Maths (A), Irish (A), Physics (B), Chemistry (C)
- **GCSEs:** Maths (A\*), Science (A\*A\*), Irish (A\*) + 1 A, 4 Bs and 1 C.

## Publications

*A Single-Significant-Digit Calculus for Semi-Automated Guesstimation* Jonathan Abourbih, **Luke Blaney**, Alan Bundy and Fiona McNeill — IJCAR 2010

## Earlier Career

- Edinburgh University Students Association, Entertainments Crew - **Lighting Technician:** 2007 - 2010
- BBC Irish Language department - **One week's Work Placement:** Summer 2009
- J Sainsbury plc - **Customer Services Assistant:** May 2005 - Dec 2005
- Andor Technology Ltd. - **One week's Work Placement:** February 2005
- Queen's University Belfast Media Services - **One week's Work Placement:** June 2003.

## Positions of Responsibility

- London Revolution Cheer - **Secretary:** 2013 - 2014.
- PHP London (including PHP UK conference 2012) - **Treasurer:** 2011 - 2012
- Edinburgh University Theatre Company - **Webmaster:** 2009 - 2010
- Edinburgh University Cheerleading Society - **Publicity Manager/Webmaster:** 2008 - 2010
- Edinburgh University Juggling Society (including 2009 Scottish Juggling convention)
  - **Secretary:** 2007 - 2008
  - **President:** 2008 - 2009
  - **Treasurer:** 2009 - 2010
- Edinburgh University Footlights - **Webmaster:** 2009 - 2010